European Commission

SPECIAL EUROBAROMETER 568

# Protecting and promoting democracy

## MOST SERIOUS CHALLENGES TO DEMOCRACY IN THE EU*



**49%** **Growing public distrust** towards democratic institutions and processes

**42%** **Foreign information manipulation**, interference and disinformation, including in the context of elections

**32%** **Lack of transparency** with regard to whether political content online is promoted through new technologies like Artificial Intelligence (AI)

**27%** **Declining opportunities** for citizens to access information and news from **independent and trustworthy media sources**

**23%** **Other attempts to destabilize elections**, such as cyberattacks

**23%** **Limited opportunities for citizens to participate** in democratic debates and policy-making processes

## ELECTIONS IN THE EU

**Regarding elections in Europe, Europeans are most concerned about**

**79%** Voters basing decisions on **disinformation**

**71%** **Cyberattacks** influencing elections

**70%** **Foreign countries** influencing elections

**67%** Election results being **manipulated**

**64%** Voters being **pressured** in their decisions

### Measures to ensure fairness of electoral campaigns online

TOP ANSWERS

**85%** **Transparency of origin** and source of political messages

**85%** **Online platforms working to prevent manipulation** of their services via fake accounts or AI-generated tools

**85%** **Equal opportunities for political parties and candidates** to access online services

**85%** **Transparency of opinion polls** about methods used and who commission them



## CITIZENS' PARTICIPATION AND ENGAGEMENT IN DECISION-MAKING IN THE EU

**Familiarity with participatory mechanisms in the EU** (citizens' assemblies, citizens' panels, citizens' juries...)



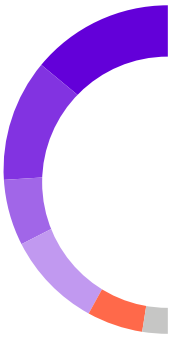
**78%** **Not familiar**

**21%** **Familiar**

**1%** Don't know

# DISINFORMATION

## Perceived exposure to disinformation and other forms of information manipulation



**28%** Every day or almost every day

**24%** At least once a week

**13%** At least once a month

**19%** Less often

**11%** Never

**5%** Don't know

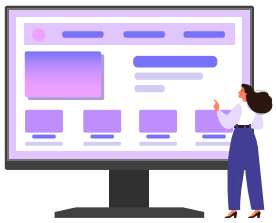
## Verifying information when using online platforms

Very often **18%**

Sometimes **33%**

Rarely **21%**

Never **26%**



## Support for actions to tackle disinformation

**44%**

**Educational programs** building critical thinking and media literacy

**41%**

**Independent fact-checking** by trustworthy organizations

**40%**

**Public awareness campaigns** to identify disinformation

**35%**

**Tools and technologies** for verifying the origin or credibility of sources

**30%**

**Easy access to independent research** and expert studies

# MEDIA FREEDOM AND PLURALISM

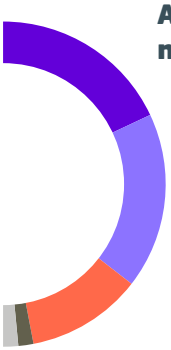
## Satisfaction with the state of media freedom, independence and pluralism in the EU

**56%** Satisfied

**40%** Not satisfied

**4%** Don't know



## According to Europeans, news media and journalism...

**36%** ... play a positive role for democracy and society

**35%** ... are a form of consumption like others

**23%** ... are not reliable sources of information

**3%** It depends

**3%** Don't know

# CIVIL SOCIETY

According to Europeans...

### ... most significant difficulties faced by civil society

**42%** Excessive administrative barriers

**41%** Lack of funding

**37%** Verbal or physical threats and attacks

### ... most significant areas of work of civil society

**42%** Exposing corruption

**41%** Defending rights of individuals

**39%** Delivering services (education, healthcare...)

* The figure show the top-6 most frequently cited items out of 7 options

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